



COSTA RICA

BORDERED BY SEA on both sides, Costa Rica differs from its neighbors in many ways. It is a peaceful country with a democratically elected government and, since 1948, no army. The country is also relatively wealthy. Schools are free, and Costa Rica spends much of its budget on education. Life expectancy in Costa Rica is the highest in Central America. Exports include coffee, bananas, and sugar, which grow on the country's fertile volcanic soils. The main port is Limón on the Caribbean coast.

COSTA RICA

Capital city: San José

Area: 19,714 sq miles (51,060 sq km)

Population: 4,200,000

Official language: Spanish

Major religions: Christian 95%, other 5%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: Costa Rican colón

Adult literacy rate: 96%

Life expectancy: 78 years

People per doctor: 1,111

Televisions: 387 per 1,000 people



THE WAY TO SAN JOSÉ

San José lies in the mountainous center of the country directly on the Pan-American Highway. It is the processing center for the crops that grow in the nearby valleys. The area developed as a tobacco growing center under Spanish rule and became the capital in 1823.

Pickers work by hand, harvesting about 55 lb (25 kg) of beans per day.



Coffee trees grow about 9.8 ft (3 m) tall.

The coffee fruit is called a cherry.

Berries turn from dark green to yellow to ripe red.

The sweet-smelling flowers last about 3 to 4 days.

Coffee is made from the two beans inside the cherry.

COFFEE BEANS

Costa Rica was the first country in Central America to grow coffee, and for more than 100 years this has been its leading export. From time to time this success is affected by falling international prices. Coffee is made from the fruit of the coffee tree, which grows best on well-drained soil. Trees need a warm, but not hot, climate, and are usually grown in areas partly shaded with larger trees. They can produce good crops for 15 years.



TRAIN TO THE COAST

The Atlantic Railway, completed in 1890, was built to take coffee from the plantations to the coast for export. The project was fraught with problems. Thousands of workers lost their lives due to terrible working conditions, and the cost plunged the government into debt.

SAVING THE FORESTS

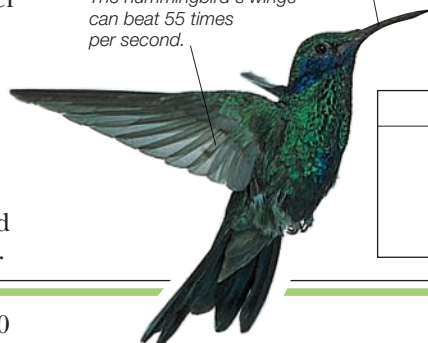
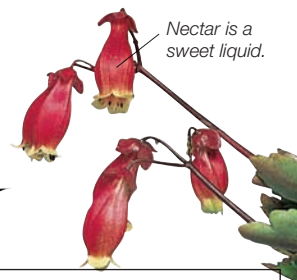
Costa Rica was once covered with forests that included mahogany and tropical cedar trees. But its tree cover has been greatly reduced because forests have been cut down for lumber and to make room for coffee plantations. However, the government is aware that loss of forest also means loss of valuable plant and animal life, and it is now working to conserve its forests. Today, much of the forest is protected in reserves and national parks.



This tiny violet-ear hummingbird is just 4.75 in (12 cm) long. It hovers in the air and takes nectar from flowers through its long beak.

The hummingbird's wings can beat 55 times per second.

Nectar is a sweet liquid.



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